

James Chambers

CLOUD DEVOPS ENGINEER

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UK national · Open to remote roles across the EU and UK

–33%

monthly cloud spend

3 wks → 20 min

application deployment

1 → 5

platform engineers, 3 countries

3M+

users on the platform

Cloud DevOps engineer on Azure and AWS, running my own Linux servers since 2010. At a 3M-user education platform I brought a hand-managed estate under pipelines and monitoring, and now run the platform behind its generative-AI product.

— EXPERIENCE

Cloud DevOps Engineer / Kortext

CONTRACT · REMOTE · AUG 2024 – PRESENT

Sole infrastructure engineer on arrival. Now own all cloud infrastructure across Azure and AWS for a platform serving 3M+ users across a portfolio of around ten products, plus the platform team I built from a standing start to five engineers in three countries.

- **Infrastructure as code.** Introduced the first CI/CD pipelines and brought a hand-managed estate under Terraform and Terragrunt, with Helm, Helmfile and ArgoCD driving GitOps delivery. A three-week manual deployment now runs as a single 20-minute pipeline.
- **Production Kubernetes.** AKS and EKS across UK, North America and Australia regions, with namespace isolation for multi-tenant client workloads, KEDA event-driven autoscaling and Goldilocks pod right-sizing.
- **Cloud cost.** Cut monthly cloud spend by 33%: tagging and Power BI visibility, right-sizing on Datadog and Goldilocks data, orphaned infrastructure decommissioned, and autoscaling on an estate that had none. Reservations last, once everything had been sized.
- **Observability and on-call.** Built out the monitoring and incident-response function: Datadog APM and synthetics, Azure Log Analytics, Application Insights and PagerDuty. Designed the first on-call rotation, staffed it as the team grew, and still own it.
- **AI incident investigation agent.** A containerised, Claude-based agent that triggers on PagerDuty incidents and posts ranked, evidenced hypotheses back within about five minutes. Read-only throughout, and hosted outside the Kubernetes estate so it works when Kubernetes is what failed.
- **AWS to Azure migration.** Migrating acquired Java and MySQL applications from AWS to Azure, cutting each client over with roughly 30 seconds of write downtime using binlog replication and a GTID-verified cutover. Compute cost down 20%, database cost down 35%.
- **Production AI platform.** Application Gateway ingress, Application Insights across six environments, and load testing. (R&D wrote the retrieval and agent layers; mine is the platform underneath.)

Cloud Platform Engineer / UK Government, Core Defra

CIVIL SERVANT · FEB 2023 – AUG 2024

- **Managed firewall rollout.** Delivered the network changes for a new managed firewall service across several hundred hub-and-spoke networks, where one wrong route-table entry takes a service off the network.
- **Legacy migration and TLS.** Migrated legacy IIS applications from on-premises into Azure with pipelines that deployed IIS on Windows VMs, and added TLS back to applications that had only ever served port 80.
- **Infrastructure build.** Built Azure infrastructure with Bicep and Microsoft's Azure Verified Modules across several hundred VMs and UK-wide database clusters, alongside on-premises domain controllers and hybrid identity.

— EARLIER

Police Constable / Northumbria Police

MAY 2018 – FEB 2023 · VOLUNTEER SPECIAL CONSTABLE TO OCT 2025

Owned the digital and financial evidence strands on a CID caseload: communications data, CCTV retention windows, payment and IP trails, RIPA/DPA applications, and forensics equipment as a digital-trained officer. It came to me because I was the most technical person on the team. Four years on frontline response before that, first on scene at grade 1 emergencies.

Freelance Web Developer — full-stack and infrastructure / Self-employed

2010 – MAY 2018 · INTERMITTENT, ALONGSIDE OTHER ROLES

Designed, built and ran all client infrastructure on bare metal and DigitalOcean: provisioning, databases, DNS, deployment and backups, where a site down meant client revenue down. Ran the full commercial cycle solo, 16 months of it entirely remote.

TOOLKIT

DELIVERY & IAC

Terraform · Terragrunt · Bicep · Azure Verified Modules · Helm · Helmfile · ArgoCD · GitOps · Azure DevOps · GitHub Actions

CLOUD

Azure · AWS · AKS · EKS · VM Scale Sets · Front Door · Application Gateway and AGIC · Container Apps · Container Instances · Azure Virtual Desktop

OPERATIONS

Datadog APM and synthetics · Log Analytics · Application Insights · PagerDuty · on-call design · incident response · KEDA · Goldilocks · Artillery · FinOps

NETWORK & SECURITY

Hub and spoke · route tables · managed firewall · WAF · private endpoints · PIM · RBAC · TLS automation

DATA

MySQL and PostgreSQL Flexible Server · SQL Managed Instance · RDS · binlog replication · GTID cutover

SCRIPTING

Bash · PowerShell · Python

CERTIFICATIONS

AZ-104 2023

Azure Administrator Associate

ITIL 4 2024

Foundation

SC-900 · MS-900 · AZ-900 2023

Security, Microsoft 365 and Azure fundamentals

CLEARANCE

Held Defra-sponsored Security Check (SC) clearance, 2023 to 2024. Now lapsed.

EDUCATION

BA (Hons) Business Management, 2:1
University of East Anglia, 2013

Level 3 NVQ Diploma in Policing
Northumbria Police, 2020

APPROACH

On cost, a fixed order: visibility, right-sizing, scaling, then reservations. Most people buy reservations first, and lock in whatever was already oversized.